

Chapter 127 - Past Dust

The initial scenes flashed by in cycles - memories she knew well.

"Ning Changfeng, wait for me!" Short-armed and short-legged, she waved her tiny sleeves, struggling to climb while following behind the woman in green robes.

The woman walked forward with her hands behind her back, traversing jagged rocks as if on flat ground with an unchanged expression: "Ning Fuyi, if you can't learn sword riding, so be it, but you're even struggling with walking. Aren't you ashamed?"

Ning Fuyi stared wide-eyed at her from behind. When she turned back, Ning Fuyi would observe her nose while her nose observed her heart, and sat down with a thud.

"Can't walk anymore..." She picked up a heavy stone and threw it hard at Ning Changfeng.

It hit Ning Changfeng's hem with a pat and rolled away like a feather.

Seeing that she couldn't defeat her mother, Ning Fuyi pouted and was about to cry. Ning Changfeng looked at her reproachfully for a moment, then walked to her side and extended her hand. Ning Fuyi, with two snot bubbles, climbed up her arm and hung onto her neck.

Ning Changfeng smelled wonderful. Ning Fuyi rubbed away her tears on her shoulder and buried her soft body in her embrace.

But Ning Changfeng didn't hold her, just let her hang there, then leaped up scattering mist and landed on the peak of Purple Cloud Peak.

Just as she landed, a white jade flute came rolling with fierce wind. Ning Changfeng smiled and rolled up her sleeves to dissipate the wind, using softness to overcome hardness and deflecting the flute's force.

Then white clothes flashed by, and the jade flute was already retrieved by its owner, graceful as snow from the ninth heaven, bringing cool and distant clouds.

"I told you not to bring this evil spawn to my Purple Cloud Peak again. Why did you bring her here? Aren't you afraid I might slip and kill her on the spot?" Chu Qingqiu's face was frosty as she swept her gaze over the little girl who didn't even reach Ning Changfeng's thigh.

Ning Fuyi didn't know why this woman called her evil spawn, nor why her eyes were full of disgust. She timidly hid behind Ning Changfeng.

Ning Changfeng paid no attention to her words, smiling as she walked toward the stone hall: "Who told you to avoid me for years? I miss you day and night, tossing and turning sleeplessly."

"Smooth talker." Chu Qingqiu said coldly, but ultimately didn't drive her away.

"However, I do have important matters. Many in the sect have gone out for training, and there's no one to watch her. I ask the Divine Venerable to help me watch her for half a day." Ning Changfeng smiled.

So after one incense stick's time, Ning Fuyi was almost thrown into the stone hall by Ning Changfeng, while the two argued outside for a while before falling silent.

Chu Qingqiu stepped through the door with an even colder expression, almost freezing water wherever she passed.

Ning Fuyi timidly curled up in a corner of the stone hall, saying quietly: "Where's my mother?"

"Dead." Chu Qingqiu said indifferently. She seemed unwilling to look at Ning Fuyi even once. Her graceful figure drifted past, and her flower-scented sleeves brushed across her cheek.

Then with a thud, Chu Qingqiu locked herself in the inner room, leaving little Ning Fuyi alone in the vast, cold stone hall.

Ning Fuyi could endure it at first, but as night fell, the stone hall became increasingly cold and piercing. Everything she touched was pitch black. Cold and frightened, Ning Fuyi had no choice but to muster her courage, push open the stone door, and crawl into the scary woman's bedchamber.

Chu Qingqiu had been meditating quietly. Hearing rustling sounds, she slowly opened her eyes, then looked displeasedly at the tiny child crawling over and sitting quietly beside her.

The child was plump and cute, but those two teardrop moles under her eyes were too striking, adding a somewhat sinister air to her rosy little face.

Chu Qingqiu looked coldly, then suddenly reached out and gripped her neck.

A child's neck was like a young bird's - soft as boneless dough. A gentle squeeze could end its life and eliminate future troubles.

Chu Qingqiu's gaze became increasingly cold and merciless, her slender fingers gradually tightening.

But at this moment, two soft little hands suddenly climbed up her arm, warm and trembling. Chu Qingqiu was stunned for an instant, and her hand immediately lost its strength.

Then her waist softened. Ning Fuyi had somehow crawled over, opened her soft little arms, and hugged her waist.

The child didn't know she had just been on the verge of death. She only knew that when Ning Changfeng extended her arms, it meant she wanted a hug, so she naturally assumed this scary aunt was the same.

Adults really were all duplicitous like this - seeming to dislike her but still wanting hugs. Ning Fuyi sighed in her heart.

Chu Qingqiu had never been close to anyone, let alone such a warm little baby. A strange feeling surged in her heart, and she immediately felt her body go soft.

When she came to her senses, she quickly shook her hand to push the child away. Although she didn't use much force, Ning Fuyi was really delicate and was directly knocked over, hitting the cold brick stones.

Ning Fuyi was both hurt and scared, looked up and wailed loudly. Chu Qingqiu was naturally irritated and said in a low voice: "Get out."

Then she pulled a cloak from the side and threw it to the child who was crying with tears and snot everywhere, emphasizing her tone: "Get out, don't come in again!"

Ning Fuyi was frightened into trembling all over. She whimpered as she grabbed the cloak and crawled out on hands and knees. After the stone door closed heavily, she cried while wrapping herself in the cloak.

The clothes carried a clear and rich floral fragrance, but Ning Fuyi was scared out of her wits by the woman and didn't find it pleasant. She knew that people in the sect more or less disliked her, but Chu Qingqiu displayed this dislike completely openly.

So little Ning Fuyi experienced heartbreak for the first time. She hid in the cloak, crying and crying until she fell into deep sleep.

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Ning Fuyi suddenly woke up.

Why would she dream of these things? She stared at the clear bright moon and laughed coldly, then struggled to get up, accidentally grabbing a handful of soil from in front of the grave, then putting it back as it was.

A few lonely stars and moon, repeatedly changing seasons - now the jade towers and precious halls had become ruins. The former prosperity and skyward fireworks were reduced to a lone, desolate grave.

"Ning Changfeng, you always said she was 'liver and gallbladder all ice and snow, inside and outside all clear and pure'¹. I say, it's nothing more than 'remaining snow condensed into ice, inside and outside all thin and heartless.'" She said drunkenly.

"You always said she was your closest friend in this life, but you don't know from the underworld that on the day you died, when I begged her to save you, she ignored me. When I begged her to appear so I could see you again, she still ignored me. I kowtowed and pleaded all night until blood stained the stone bricks, and in the end only received an order to leave."

"She is the stars and moon of the ninth heaven, I am the mud of the mortal world. It's natural that she dislikes me."

Ning Fuyi spoke drunkenly and incoherently, reaching for the remaining wine to drink, feeling the dead branches overhead spinning.

"Now I've destroyed Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate too. Do you blame me?" Ning Fuyi wiped the wine stains from her lips and pressed against the tombstone regardless of the mud, the stone tablet like carved jade under the moon.

She smashed the jar and hugged the tombstone tightly, like in childhood when she would wrap her arms around her mother's neck.

"I hate this world where everyone wants me dead. If you blame me, take me away so I won't stain my hands with more blood." She grinned viciously. "I'll destroy the six realms and return them to chaos, so there will be no more suffering in the world!"

She drunkenly held the tombstone and rambled for half the night, until the moon set and stars shifted, with mist drifting north.

Seeing dawn about to break, Ning Fuyi looked up and wiped the moisture from her face, turned the wine jars on the ground to powder, then stumbled down the mountain.

At first she didn't notice anything unusual, until a gust of wind blew and she trembled in shock, looking up at the sky that had somehow filled with dark clouds. Black clouds rolled over the mountaintop, crackling lightning hidden in the clouds, producing rumbling thunder.

The weather had been clear as water just moments ago, but now there were such strange phenomena - definitely not ordinary. Ning Fuyi quickly dispelled her drunkenness and summoned her Emei thorns with a wave.

If any immortal sect dared to offend again, she happened to have drunken rage with nowhere to vent - she'd make sure they never returned! Ning Fuyi smiled bloodthirstily, lightning reflected in her phoenix eyes.

But suddenly a thunderbolt struck down from above. Ning Fuyi was about to raise her hand to block it, but this thunder didn't seem like any person's immortal power - it was full of overwhelming pressure, as heavy as world-destroying force. Ning Fuyi didn't dare meet it head-on and quickly spun to dodge. The mountain peak beneath her feet was struck and a chunk fell off, revealing pale interior.

"It's heavenly thunder!" Ning Fuyi broke out in cold sweat. Could it be that her evil deeds yesterday were too severe, provoking Heaven's wrath?

But this heavenly thunder didn't seem directed at her, because in an instant the mountains split in all directions, and even the rivers below broke their waterways, overflowing in all directions.

Oh no, Ning Changfeng's grave! Ning Fuyi quickly ran back to the original spot and waved her hand to form a barrier covering the tomb, but she was ultimately a step too late. A thunder bright as the sun fell in the blink of an eye, shaking mountains and rivers. The tombstone immediately turned to powder, and the entire mountain peak became smoke and dust.

Ning Fuyi was instantly swept away by the rising gale, falling into the completely destroyed mountain ravine along with the dust. She had already fought for three days and nights and was extremely exhausted, plus drunk and unsteady - she could no longer resist, so she closed her eyes and let herself fall.

Falling and falling, until everything around was pitch black.

She didn't know how long passed before Ning Fuyi woke up again.

Her whole body ached with fatigue. She lay on her back on flat ground with what seemed like trickling water flowing beneath her. Her feet drifted with the water like water plants, and the smell of green grass filled her nostrils.

Ning Fuyi's eyelids fluttered. Overhead there were still dark clouds wrapping muffled thunder, with threads of lightning shuttling through the thick cloud layers.

She wearily scooped up a handful of clear water and splashed it on her face. As she became alert, it also moistened her dry lips, and she slowly sat up.

Most of her drunken stupor had dissipated. She could tell she wasn't at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate now, but by a quiet lakeside. Here the water plants were lush, but there were no bird songs or wild beasts.

Ning Fuyi got up and stepped out of the lakeside, raised her hand to dry her black clothes, bound her long hair with a tree branch, and stumbled toward where the lightning was flickering.

This place was too vast - so vast it was deathly silent. At the farthest point the dark clouds were thinner, revealing faint skylight that illuminated the mountains, dyeing the peaks golden.

Lightning was still striking down one bolt after another, all aimed at the same location, as if someone was suffering thunder punishment. Even the most terrible punishments she'd seen didn't have such short intervals. Ning Fuyi shivered.

She walked over a hillside and the view suddenly opened up. Below the slope was a plain where the grass had already been scorched, with a large pit blasted out by lightning in the center, fire light blazing skyward from within.

Another bolt of lightning struck down. Ning Fuyi retreated a few steps, squinting up at the sky. The clouds were thinner now, and the thunder punishment seemed to have stopped.

She waited a moment more until she was sure no more lightning would come, then quickly walked to the edge of the pit and looked down, involuntarily gasping.

There was indeed someone at the bottom of the pit - a woman whose clothes had long been torn to barely cover her body, only covered by a mass of scorched black hair scattered over her. The exposed skin was covered with wounds left by lightning, shocking to see.

One hand stretched outside, five fingers deeply embedded in the mud, as if she had tried to crawl out but had no strength left.

A thin rope hung on her dirty wrist, strung with a black bead that hadn't been stained by dust.

"Hey!" Ning Fuyi grabbed a handful of dead grass from beside her and scattered it into the pit. The grass fell sparsely onto her body, causing the woman to tremble for an instant.

The hair on her body moved, and a pair of peach blossom eyes opened through it, looking up at Ning Fuyi from afar.

Author's Note: The timeline should be after the little white dog died in the previous life, when Ning Fuyi attacked the immortal sects.

Footnotes:

1. **"Liver and gallbladder all ice and snow, inside and outside all clear and pure" (肝胆皆冰雪，表里俱澄澈)** - This is a classical Chinese poetic expression describing someone as being pure, noble, and transparent in character both inside and out, comparing them to ice, snow, and clear water.